| LEAD ESSAY |

THE COALITION DHARMA

THE UPA'S DECADE BEGAN BY CHANCE, GOVERNED THROUGH CONSENSUS AND WELFARE, UNRAVELLED AMID POLICY PARALYSIS AND CORRUPTION SCANDALS, AND ENDED BY CLEARING THE GROUND FOR MODI'S RISE

By **RAJDEEP SARDESAI**

'I **see myself in public service, not in politics,' affirmed Dr Manmohan Singh.** We were interviewing him in his book-lined study, a sanctuary of sorts for the blue turban-wearing academic-turned-neta. The year was 1999, and the soft-spoken, scholarly Congressman was fighting his first Lok Sabha election in South Delhi against the BJP's experienced warhorse, Vijay Kumar Malhotra. Not surprisingly, a tentative Dr Singh lost by a sizeable margin. And yet, in a remarkable twist of fortune, just five years later, the 'accidental' politician was being sworn in as prime minister.

In a sense, 2004 was an 'accidental' general election, one where a Congress party, widely written off as a tottering relic in decline, a leftover from a hoary *ancien régime*, suddenly found itself leading a coalition government. The popular incumbent Atal Bihari Vajpayee had been trumped by a mix of complacency, alliance missteps and unexpected state-level results. When Sonia Gandhi, rather dramatically, announced that she would listen to her 'inner voice' and decline prime ministership, Dr Singh was instantly catapulted as her preferred choice. It marked the onset of a topsy-turvy decade that would begin with the Left in ascendancy but culminate with the inexorable rise of the Right.

The United Progressive Alliance (UPA), as the new government was christened, was forged more in hope than conviction, a patchwork arrangement held together by a fierce desire to keep the BJP out of power at all costs. The Left parties, in particular, had been staunch opponents of economic liberalisation, the calling card of Dr Singh, and his eponymously named 'Manmohanomics', when he was finance minister in the 1990s. When the stock markets tumbled, fearing that the UPA would reverse market-friendly reforms under Left pressure, CPI leader A.B. Bardhan instinctively blurted, '*Bhaad mein jaaye stock market* (The market can go to hell)!'. A gov-

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